Twist

By Cora Sorenson

Samantha, 17 or 18, is intelligent, well-spoken and charming. The short vignettes are reenacted with the single performer embodying the persona of the other characters.

SAMANTHA: (Pg 23-31) *(singing)* ***** *I never meant 2 cause you any sorrow. I never meant 2 cause you any pain. I only wanted 2 see u laughing in the purple rain. I only wanted 2 see u baby in the purple rain.*

Every good story ends with a twist. Well, at least in my opinion they do. Who wants to read a novel where you spend so many hundred pages getting to know the characters, actually end up caring about them and then . . . Bam! They just end up doing what people would do in real life. Or you shell out nine bucks for a movie and by the time the two hours is up, somehow, magically, everything works out perfectly. Boy meets girl. Girl gets pissed off at boy. Boy goes to extraordinary means to get girl back. Girl forgives boy and they ride off into the sunset. Sure. People in real life do what we expect them to do. Always. We escape into entertainment hoping something different will happen. So, that's why I decided I'd make sure my story would have a twist at the end. Maybe I've ruined the surprise by announcing it upfront; but, sometimes, for things to make sense, you have to start at the end of the story.

INTRODUCTION

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SAMANTHA: There's a zillion different places where the story could start. I mean, I could go back to how my parents met at their Ivy League schools, fell madly in love (supposedly), made all sorts of money in the professions of medicine and law and then decided to have me. But I'm not going to start with that. I'm going to start with Fluffy, Mrs. Butterbutt and Samantha. Fluffy was my loyal hamster when I was five. Mrs. Butterbutt was my kindergarten teacher. And, in case, you haven't figured it out, I'm

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Samantha. So, anyway, I adored Fluffy and I hated Mrs. Butterbutt. Fluffy was always there to listen to all of my problems and comfort me -- everything anyone could ever want in a hamster. Mrs. Butterbutt, on the other hand, was an old cow who appeared to exist only to make my life a living hell. For example: *(re-enactment – age 5)*

SAMANTHA: The other girls are being mean to me again, Mrs. B.

MRS. B: You have to kill them with kindness, Samantha, dear.

SAMANTHA: I have to kill Andrea and Melissa?

MRS. B: No, no, no, dear. You have to be nice to them, even when they're mean to you.

SAMANTHA: Even when they call me ogre, giant girl or redwood tree?

MRS. B: Yes, dear, even then.

SAMANTHA: But Mrs. B didn't have to spend day in and day out with Andrea and Melissa. Mrs. B didn't have to walk around being twice as big as all the other little girls. You don't get called "redwood tree" for nothing. She pretended to be a nice old lady, but really she was meaner than the witch from Hansel and Gretel. And no, the twist isn't that I baked Mrs. B in an oven.

So, back to Fluffy. One day I come home from kindergarten hell to find Fluffy with four feet in the air. Traumatizing, let me tell you. Mom and dad explained how Fluffy was very old for a hamster and had gone to hamster heaven. I got all that, I was a bright kid. But the thing was, why hadn't Mrs. Butterbutt gone to kindergarten teacher/wicked witch heaven? Cuz she was ***really*** old. Really, ***really*** old.

So, the years passed like the middle pages of a long novel. The ones you only skim through and don't really read because you're trying to get to the end . . . to the twist. And we get to the part of the narrative where I'm in high school. Some time in high school, I think girls make a decision. They either decide they are going to devote every moment of their time to obtaining that holiest of holies - a boyfriend - or they are just going to resign themselves to never having one. I decided that having a group of friends (some of whom happened to be reasonably cute boys) was good enough for me. Until the spring of my 11th grade year when Ricky asked me if I would

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go to the junior prom with him. Sort of like this:

RICKY: Sam, would you go to junior prom with me?

SAMANTHA: Pardon?

RICKY: You know, the event where everybody gets dressed up, dances, eats and sneaks out to go drinking afterwards?

SAMANTHA: yeah. Umm, as friends, you mean?

RICKY: Samantha! As my date!

SAMANTHA: Okay, cut. I'm a big girl, but not an idiot. Sorry to disappoint, but I did not go through any low-self esteem crap, self-loathing, etc, etc. I just said yes. Ricky is about an inch shorter than me, varsity swimmer, and, umm . . . Has these blue eyes. I'm trying to think of some poetic description . . . They're just these clear, blue reflections . . . Like you can see yourself there when you look into them.

So we went to prom. And then we started doing this thing that all my friends had been doing for awhile. Teenagers in the wild call it "dating." For a while, I was really suspicious. Like, this was going to turn out just like one of those movies where the girl gets to date the gorgeous guy for a while only to find out she's the victim of some bet. But, the more Ricky said to me, the less suspicious I was. So, we went to the lake together and swam.

RICKY: I like your smile.

SAMANTHA: He took me to a comedy show and actually paid.

RICKY: I love your laugh. Don't ever stop laughing.

SAMANTHA: We ate Lebanese food and he gave me a ring he'd made in metal shop.

RICKY: I was waiting for you, Samantha.

SAMANTHA: We laid out on a blanket, drank apple cider from the same thermos and he kissed me.

RICKY: I think I'm falling in love with you, Sam.

SAMANTHA: I always thought "love" was the worst cliche of any novel, of any stupid teen movie. But maybe we think a lot of things are stupid until we understand what they

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are. I probably sound like a big giant cliche with extra cheese right now, and I don't even care. My heart started to feel. And I fell in love with Ricky. My parents were overjoyed. Parents never see the flaws in their kids, not ever, so I guess they couldn't understand why I hadn't been snatched up earlier.

About a year after the prom, Ricky and I were going to spend the weekend at my parent's lake house. We were excited, ya know, graduation was only a couple of months away. On Saturday afternoon, though, I had to drive back to town to study for my calc final with some friends. Ricky decided to stay ... He was going to swim, study, whatever. I thought I'd be gone 'til the evening, but Deidre had a headache and we cut studying short. I drove back, and, you know, I didn't think anything of the car outside the house . . . Not anything . . . Just figured he'd invited someone over. I walked in the front door, and Ricky was there with Kristy, a cheerleader, and, uh, their clothes were off, strewn across the floor. . . uh . . . I didn't say anything, really. Ricky's eyes, though, his blue glacier eyes, met mine and ***he*** said things. His mouth moved and sounds fell out, like lines from a movie, like . . .

RICKY: Samantha, what are you doing back? I, uh, I didn't. I didn't mean to. I, uh . . .

SAMANTHA: And I don't think I said anything back, really. I was dizzy and my heart was pounding . . . just pounding. And then I heard a car starting, wheels going over gravel and then Ricky and . . . that girl . . . were gone. I sat there for a while, very quiet, and then I went home.

I waited three days. Didn't see him. He wasn't at school. And then I called him. What you may not be aware of is that more than 3/4 of intimate relationships survive when one person cheats. I just needed . . . wanted to talk to him. And, the thing you need to understand, is that he wouldn't talk to me. And that was what started the shattering. Seeing him there, with Kristy hurt. But him not being willing to talk, to work this out -- it made me feel like my body was breaking apart. I tried to explain to him that we could work this out, but he wasn't listening ... He just kept saying

RICKY: Goodnight, Samantha. . .

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SAMANTHA: Over and over. And then he hung up. *(singing) I never wanted to be your weekend lover. I only wanted 2 be some kind of friend. I could never steal u from another. It's such a shame our friendship had 2 end. I only wanted 2 see u underneath the purple rain . . .*

So this catches us up to right this very instant. With me standing on the deck of my parent's lake house. No, this isn't the part of the story where you start to feel sorry for the girl who was made fun of her whole childhood only to get dumped by the first boy she really loved. Don't you dare feel sorry for me. If you do, you're missing the point altogether and you won't get the twist.

All he had to do was talk to me. That's all. And he wouldn't. If this was a movie, I would eventually get over it. Or, in some fantasy, he and I might even get back together. But this isn't those things. This is my life.

Ricky is inside now -- Just a few steps away. After all these times of me asking to talk, he finally agreed. Said he would give me an hour tonight. But the time is up. The chance is over. Like a chemical reaction that's expired. No talking tonight. . . no.

I think I told you that my father was a physician, right? I think I did. You may not be aware, but there's a drug called "Vionox"- a drug that paralyzes the body but keeps the person alert. I lifted some from the hospital, and Ricky is inside there now, experiencing the effects. He's lying very still, his blue eyes wide open but he can't move.

I didn't want to struggle with him. I'm a big girl, after all, but he's strong. *(picks up a bat, or sledgehammer from the deck, swings it)* What you may not be aware of is that the human skull and the brain can sustain between four and six direct hits with a heavy blunt object before it gives up . . . expires. *(beat)* I am not a tragic heroine. I refuse. I will never be made fun of again, by the girls in kindergarten, by Mrs. Butterbutt, by Ricky - the boy who has no heart. *(beat)* Every action has a consequence. In a book or a movie, I would get over all of this . . . But I decided my story would have a twist. Did

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you see it coming? They say there's only so many plot lines, you know. *(beat)*

Afterwards, maybe I'll call the police. Or my mother. She's an attorney, remember? She's always told me, "It's not about whether or not someone did something bad, just whether or not they have a lot of money. Justice is very expensive."

Maybe I'll say he tried to rape me or attacked me first. I'll decide something. *(beat)* I have to go now. I have to tell Ricky goodnight. *(sings as she exits)* "Honey, I know times r changin'. It's time we all reach out 4 somethin' new that means u 2. U say u want a leader But u can't seem 2 make up your mind. I think u better close it and let me guide u 2 the purple rain."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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Song music and lyrics to Purple Rain by Prince can be found here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OOM6TiWJdps

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